Animals

By Simon Rich

PRINCESS JASMINE: **(Pg 1-18)** They buried my wife in a shoebox in Central Park. I like to imagine that the service was respectful, that her body was treated with a modicum of dignity. But of course, I'll never know. I wasn't invited to her funeral. Instead, the guests of honor were the students of homeroom 2K . . . Her killers.

Hailey, I noticed, was crying. The irony. It was her responsibility to refill our water bottle last week. Instead, she spent all her free time with Alyssa, practicing a clapping game called "Miss Mary Mack."

HAILEY: *(with enthusiasm)* ***Miss Mary Mack, Mack, Mack! All dressed in black, black, black!***

PRINCESS JASMINE: It was that inane chant that provided the score to my wife's final moments. . . Pocahontas was her name.

INTRODUCTION

By the time Simon Rich graduated from Harvard he had a two-book deal from Random House. He also spent four years writing for Saturday Night Live (the youngest writer SNL ever hired) and about two years at Pixar and is now at work on a film and a television series. His stories eccentric, universally hilarious and often built on an unusual premise, or told from a surprising angle. This tale takes a looks at a typical week in a 2nd grade classroom of a elite private school . . . but the twist? Our narrator is a widowed hamster named . . . (wait for it) PRINCESS JASMINE!

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PRINCESS JASMINE: My name is Princess Jasmine. I am a male, so this name is humiliating, but I'm aware that my situation could be worse. The other homeroom, 2R, has a guinea pig named Homer Simpson and an elderly turtle named New Kids on the Block.

Pocahontas left me with three sons, and it's for their sake alone that I keep up my struggle. Their names are Big Mac, Whopper, and Mr. T.

It's morning now. The square of sunlight on the blackboard grows and grows. Soon the gremlins will run in howling, hopped up on Pop-Tarts and primed for violence. It turns out

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this school is a private one, an "elite" institution for the children of millionaires. I can hear the nannies muscling their way through the lobby, dragging their little terrors toward my family. The bell clangs harshly. The nightmare has begun.

Monday

MS. HUDSON: What time is it?

SIMON: Jobs time!

PRINCESS JASMINE: My fur bristles as Ms. Hudson takes out the Jobs Board. This laminated poster, with its seventeen colorful squares, rules my family's existence. It determines everything: whether we feast or starve, live or die. I rub my paws impatiently while Ms. Hudson assigns the week's tasks. . . Pencil organizer . . . . Table Wipers . . . Eventually, she gets to the one job that matters.

MS. HUDSON: Hamster feeder is…

PRINCESS JASMINE: I scan the room. There are still some good candidates left. Maybe we'll get lucky and end up with Caitlin? Last time she gave us double portions. It's while I'm enjoying this fantasy that Ms. Hudson clears her throat and—with one little word—sentences my family to death.

MS. HUDSON: …Simon.

PRINCESS JASMINE: My eyes widen with horror.

SIMON: *(shouting)* Hamster feeder? Whatchu talkin' 'bout Willis!

PRINCESS JASMINE: The other children laugh hysterically. *My God*, I think. *This is it. This is how it ends.*

PRINCESS JASMINE: 11:25 am . . . I sigh with relief as Simon finally walks over to our cage. He doesn't feed us, though, or replenish our water. Instead, he picks me up by my tail, which is connected directly to my spine. He swings me through the air drops me back into my cage My sons poke their heads through the newspaper. They look around confusedly, then stare at me in dismay. They're used to receiving food at this hour, but I have none to give. Simon has forgotten to do his one basic task. Our long, slow death march has started.

Tuesday

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PRINCESS JASMINE: I awake to the sound of screeching laughter. Sophie and Alyssa have made a dress out of pink construction paper and taped it to my sleeping body.

ALYSSA: You're a pretty girl, Princess Jasmine! A pretty, pretty girl!

PRINCESS JASMINE: I try to remove the costume, but the tape is double-sided and my paws are too weak to detach it. I must wear this "dress" indefinitely, in the presence of my own sons. I avoid their eyes, and they avoid mine. Whatever dignity I had is long gone. I can feel myself on the verge of becoming insane.

When the final school bell rings. Carlos, the janitor walks from table to table, cleaning up after the beasts. The Jobs Board is a total farce, I think, as he sponges up their filth. Kristen and Sophie are table wipers in name only. At the end of the day, every job on the board belongs to Carlos. When Carlos sees us, he curses under his breath. I avert my eyes with shame. Our cage is full of feces. I know we're not responsible for the condition of our prison, but it's hard not to feel mortified. I look on with pity as the janitor collects our soiled newspaper. He refills our water bottle, and, for the first time in days, I allow myself to feel hope. Before he can find our feedbag, though, Principal Davenport has run into the room.

PRINCIPAL DAVENPORT: Carlos, there you are! A kindergartener [soiled] himself in dance. Would you please take care of it?

PRINCESS JASMINE: Carlos forces another smile and reaches for his mop.

Wednesday

PRINCESS JASMINE: The water tastes so rich it brings tears to my eyes. As I drink it, I can feel it coursing through my body, giving my parched veins life. I look over at my sons, asleep in their clean cage, their wet little noses twitching with contentment. Carlos has saved our lives. But for how long?

Mercifully, the children are gone this morning. They've been given a break from their arduous studies to enjoy a "field day" at Randall's Island. The classroom is blissfully quiet until lunchtime, when the hobgoblins return. Their red faces are streaked with grime and sweat. The smell is almost unendurable. Every child has somehow won an athletic trophy.

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SIMON: *(Raising his golden prize over his head, he shouts)* Boom shaka laka!

PRINCESS JASMINE: When he walks by my cage, I peak at the engraving on his trophy. "Participation," it reads. I wonder if Simon is aware that his trophy has no meaning, that all he participated in was a mass delusion?

MS. HUDSON: Great job, everybody. That was some *great* teamwork today. Don't forget to do your jobs!

PRINCESS JASMINE: Simon doesn't even look in our direction. This makes three straight days without food. It's official: we are going to starve to death.

Thursday

PRINCESS JASMINE: As the sun rises on another hellish day, I gather my sons around me. I've rehearsed my speech all night, but it's still hard to utter it. Eventually, with painful effort, I manage to force the terrible words through my lips. "If Simon forgets to feed us one more time… I want the three of you to eat my body." Mr. T breaks down and weeps. But Big Mac and Whopper merely nod. They know it's the only solution we have left.

I can hear Simon's voice before he even enters the classroom, as piercing and abrasive as a siren.

SIMON: Whatchu talkin' 'bout Willis! *(As he presses his face against the bars of the hamster cage, he chants again and again)* Whatchu talkin' 'bout! Whatchu talkin' 'bout! Whatchu talkin' 'bout!

PRINCESS JASMINE: His noxious Dorito breath engulfs me and I can feel the fury mounting in my chest. I think of the sound of my son weeping and the look my wife gave me as she drew her final breath. I have only a little strength left. But it's enough to rise up and sink my teeth into the monster's flesh.

Friday

PRINCESS JASMINE: Our cage has been moved to the principal's office,

PRINCIPAL DAVENPORT: Words can't express how sorry I am! Safety is our top priority—I'm as appalled as you are that something like this could occur at our school.

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SIMON'S MOTHER: He had to get three stitches! The plastic surgeons say that the scar could be visible for months!

PRINCESS JASMINE: I roll my eyes as Simon's mother starts to cry.

SIMON'S MOTHER: He's just a little boy. And you let him be exposed to wild animals! I'm considering pressing charges. My lawyer says I have a real case. Simon had to take a rabies test, and when the nurse pricked his thumb, he cried and cried. The doctor said he'd never seen a boy cry like that.

PRINCESS JASMINE: I smile proudly, thinking of this scene. [Then] Simon's mother turns toward our cage, her eyes narrowing with rage.

SIMON'S MOTHER: I want those animals out of the classroom . . . I want them d***estroyed***.

PRINCIPAL DAVENPORT: *(clearing his throat)* Of course. *(He picks up a phone and calls for a janitor)*

PRINCESS JASMINE: Carlos arrives within seconds, mop in hand . . . . I can smell the Dumpster before I see it, an overflowing bin of putrid trash. My nose twitches painfully as I process all the stenches: decomposing Dunkaroos and mold-encrusted Pop-Tarts; rancid, soggy Lunchables and spoiled Nesquik. The monsters have accumulated so much waste this week, and now we're to be added to the pile.

CARLOS: *(whispering)* Sorry, little guys. *(He scans the alley to make sure no children are watching, then tucks the cage under his arm and runs)*

Saturday

PRINCESS JASMINE: I awake to the sight of three girl humans, gobbling pancakes and chatting rapidly.

GIRL 1: What do we name the babies?

GIRL 2: Snap, Crackle, and Pop!

GIRL 3: The mommy should be Mrs. Fluffy, or Mrs. Furry, or…

CARLOS: *(interrupting)* It's not a mommy. It's a daddy. And we're going to call him Hercules.

GIRL 1: *(laughing)* Hercules! *Why*?

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CARLOS: *(Crouching down and looking into Hercules' eyes)* Because he's tough. And strong. And he works long hours, even though it's a living nightmare. *(There is a sense he is talking about himself too)*

GIRL 2: *(looking around nervously, she whispers)* O.K. We'll call him Hercules.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Simon Rich
Book: Spoiled Brats, Pg 1-18
ISBN: 978-0316368629
Publisher: Little, Brown and Company
Date (Month/Year): Oct 2014

AWARD HISTORY

2019 National Qualifier
2023 National Qualifier
2024 National Qualifier
2024 National Qualifier - MS
NIETOC
CO State Qualifier
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MN State Qualifier

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